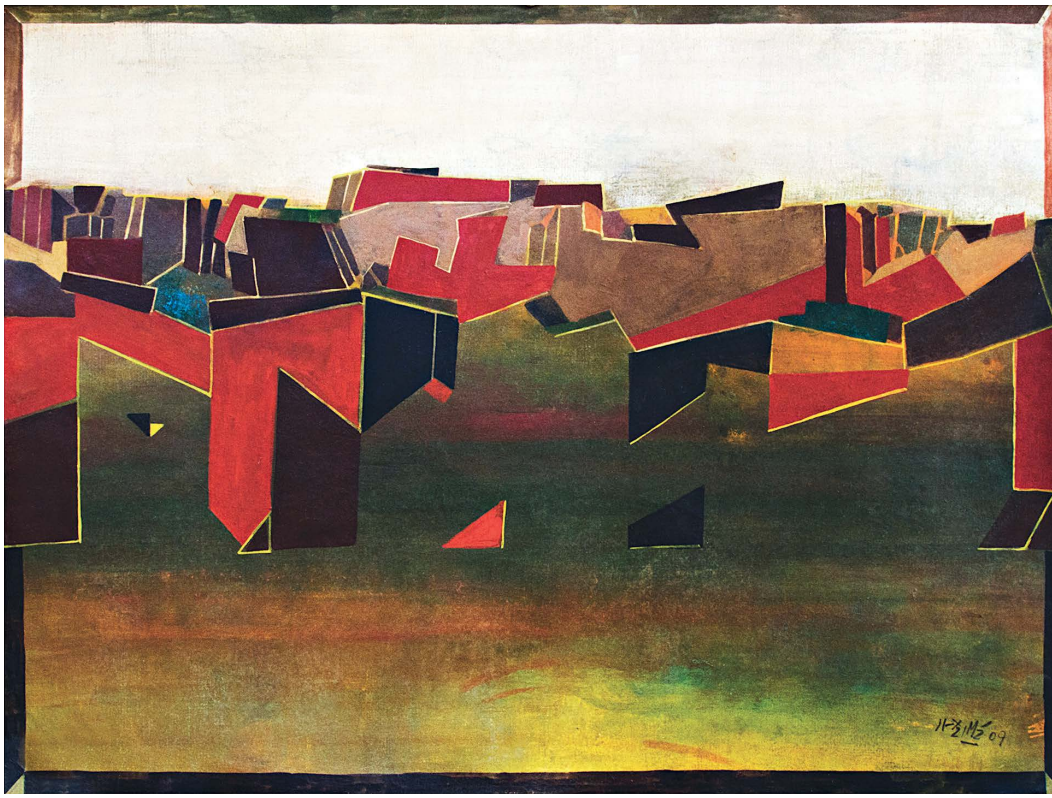
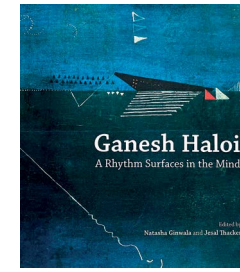


ART AS LANGUAGE
An untitled gouache artwork from 2007 by Ganesh Haloi

GANESH HALOI: A Rhythm Surfaces in the Mind
Edited by Natasha Ginwala and Jesal Thacker
MAPIN PUBLISHING & AKAR PRAKAR
₹2,500; 256 pages



Ganesh Haloi: A Rhythm Surfaces in the Mind is, like its title, about the melody evoked by the artist's earth-toned abstract oeuvre. This recently published monograph brought out by Mapin Publishing and Akar Prakar, and edited by Natasha Ginwala and Jesal Thacker, traverses the artist's six-decade practice and, in the process, raises as many questions as it answers.

While much has been written on Haloi, including an autobiography, *Amar Katha,* which won the Manojmohan Basu Smarak Samman from the Paschimbanga Bangla Akademi, this book looks at his artistic practice as adjacent to and not just as a result of the tumultuous upheavals of his life. Featuring essays from curators and critics, and many of Haloi's hitherto unseen works, sketches as well as familiar gouaches and watercolours, the book is an immersive study of the artist and his practice.

Is his art abstract? It is and "infinitely so", argues the chair of the department of history of art at Cornell University, Iftikhar Dadi, in his essay 'Infinite Abstraction' as he tries to "situate him in a larger framework of global abstraction, whose claims are local as well as universal". Haloi is "an abstract painter", writes Dadi, "whose thinking and practice have been forged in the context of three deep and intense engagements of his life" in Jamalpur, in Bangladesh, where the artist grew up; in Kolkata, where he later had to move to in 1950 after the threat of communal violence; and Ajanta, where he was posted for seven years on an assignment of rendering copies of the murals. Dadi argues that abstraction in the South Asian context had "affiliations across the partitioned continent with shared refrains" with artists and academics like Mohammad Kibria, Nasreen Mohamedi and Lala Rukh.

But Haloi himself disagrees. Clad in his trademark earthy khadi kurta and pyjama, he says over sips of *laal cha*, "I can see it. All that one sees in my work I can see it and feel it." He reaches for a sheet of paper and draws a vertical line on it and asks, "Isn't this a tree?" A cross goes over the line and it becomes a palm tree. A triangle, a circle, a wavy line and a slanting line follow. "Show this to anyone and they will say this is a mountain and a tree by the river," he challenges.

Haloi goes on to explain, in his gentle teacherly voice, as he draws on the same sheet of paper what look like symbols for subtraction, addition, multiplication and division. "This minus sign is death, when another is born you add to it and there is addition," he says. Haloi's thought continues in Thacker's essay 'Processing a Line', which looks at "the axis of life as a *rekha* or line that governs the unknown". "The vertical line atop the